

BigSkyAstro

User Manual

Manual PDF

Help PDF

Test Checklist

Help Page

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IPHONE AND IPAD GUIDE

BigSky Planner iOS User Manual

A screenshot-guided manual for BigSky Planner iOS Release 17 (3), covering setup, locations, telescope, targets, planner, weather, updates, and troubleshooting.

Release: 17 (3)

Updated: 2026-07-16

Set up the observing site

Filter target catalogs

Build and print plans

Check weather and darkness

Update comet and asteroid data

Find quick answers

Download User Manual

Open Latest Help Page

Download Help PDF

Download Test Checklist

Chapters

Use this page as the map for the manual. Each topic starts on its own page in the PDF so the guide is easier to scan during setup or while observing.

01 First Start Setup

Internet permission, privacy review, language, first location, telescope, and plan folder.

02 Home

Telescope initialize and stop tracking time, main actions, and the bottom information card.

03 Locations

GPS, manual entry, Address Info, default site, elevation, scrolling, and canceling a new location.

04 Telescope

Smart telescope and accessory selection used in observing plans.

05 Target Setup

Catalog, Time, Filter, Current Setup, red/green card status, and stale target update behavior.

06 Advanced Filters and Results

Magnitude, altitude, azimuth, object types, Clear Sky ranges, duration, target details, and validation.

07 Observation Time

Target start/stop time, after-midnight handling, and overlap checks.

08 Planner

Review targets, sort, save, preview, print, share, load, and delete plans.

09 Weather and Sky Info

Date/time period, source, Update, Sunset, Sunrise, Bortle/SQM, darkness, and hourly forecast rows.

10 Set Up

Language, units, internet permission, database updates, small-body updates, and About This App.

11 Help and Clock Support

In-app help and HHMM, 12-hour, and 24-hour time entry.

12 Troubleshooting

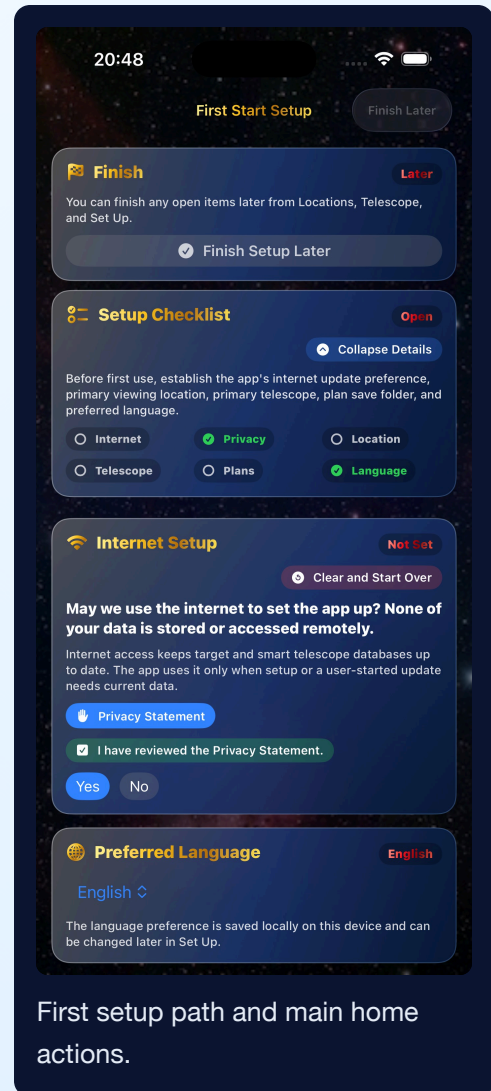
Fast fixes for blank weather, missing targets, stale asteroid/comet data, and PDF or print issues.

13 Quick Answer Index

End-of-manual index for common questions and the topic that answers them.

First Start Setup

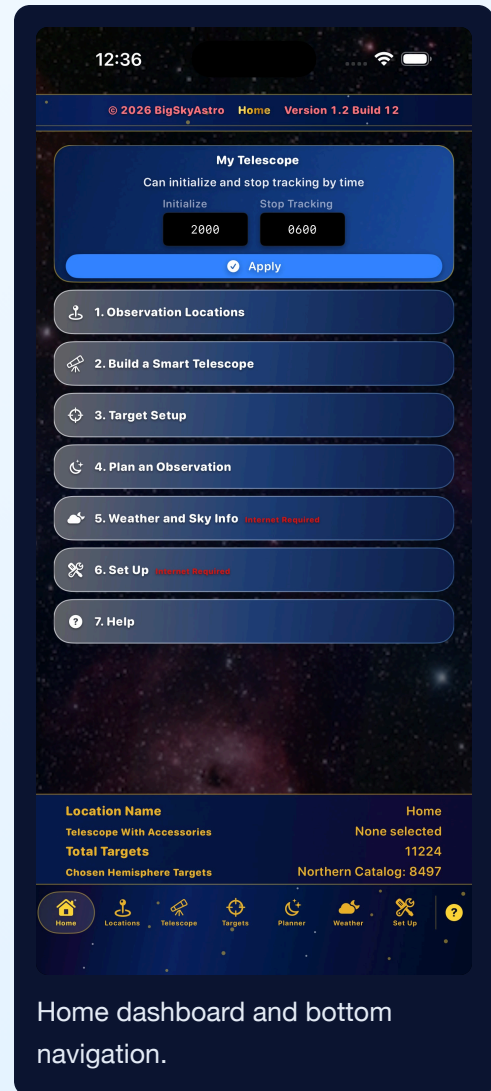
- Answer whether the app may use the internet for setup and user-started database updates.
- Open the Privacy Statement link before answering if you want to review data handling. Set Up shows that local privacy review state later.
- Completed Internet, Privacy, and Plan Save Folder actions dim after they are set; use Clear and Start Over to reset first-start setup.
- The Finish card and Setup Checklist stay pinned. The Setup Checklist starts collapsed by default and can be expanded when the checklist detail is needed.
- Choose preferred language, primary viewing location, and primary telescope with accessories.
- After saving the primary telescope, the telescope editor collapses to the saved telescope/accessory summary and setup moves toward the plan folder step.
- Choose or create a plan folder in Files, or save the folder setting to complete that setup item.
- Use Finish Later only after the internet permission question has been answered.



First setup path and main home actions.

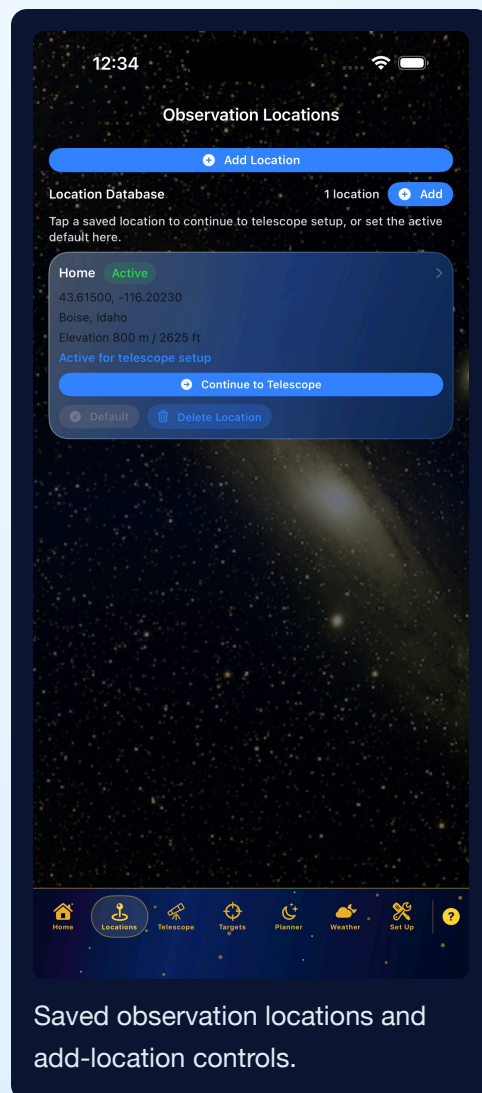
Home

- Home opens Locations, Telescope, Targets, Planner, Weather, Set Up, and Help.
- The My Telescope card shows the saved default telescope name and calculates initialize and stop-tracking times from the current phone location when available, or from the saved default location.
- All Vaonis smart telescopes use the calibrated Vespera II Singularity window. Unistellar, ZWO Seestar, Celestron, DWARFLAB, and unconfirmed models use their current readiness estimates.
- The calculated Vaonis field window is labeled ± 1 minute because minute rounding can differ slightly by date and source.
- Time entry still accepts HHMM, 12-hour, and 24-hour values.
- Applying the telescope time window saves the observing window used by weather and target planning, then routes you to location setup.
- The compact top banner leaves room for the action buttons and bottom data card on iPhone.
- The My Telescope card uses tighter padding so the lower information card stays readable.
- The taller bottom data card shows Location Name, Telescope With Accessories, Total Targets, and Chosen Hemisphere Targets in larger dark yellow text on the standard blue background.



Locations

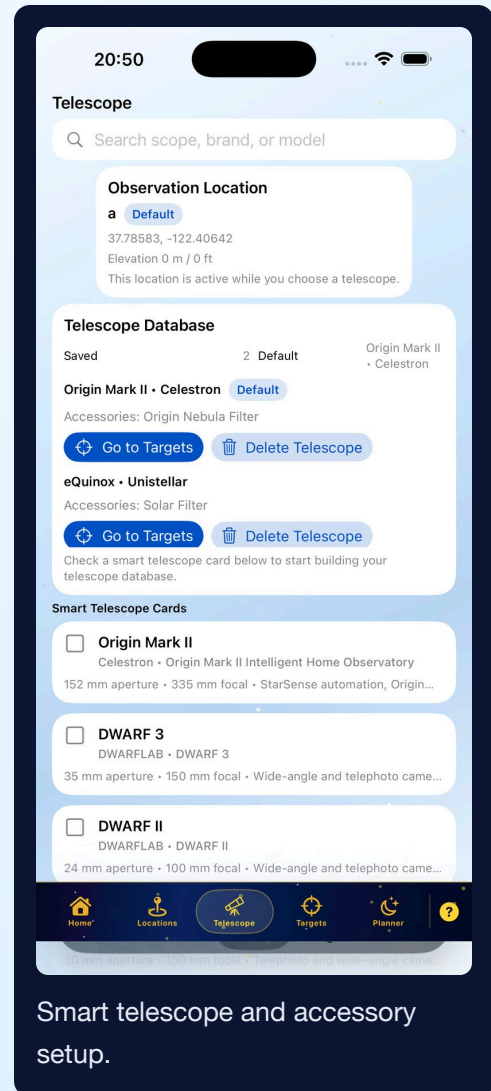
- Save at least one valid observing location before target filtering or weather.
- Use GPS when available. After GPS fills the site, Address Info collapses automatically and can be expanded again.
- If you start a new location card, use Cancel to leave without saving it.
- Manual address entry starts with Country so address labels match the selected country.
- The page scrolls while editing so lower fields and saved locations remain reachable.
- Only one saved location can be default at once.
- Set Default promotes a saved location without re-entering site details, and Delete Location removes old sites.
- Elevation is saved when available and is used for weather pressure adjustments.



Saved observation locations and add-location controls.

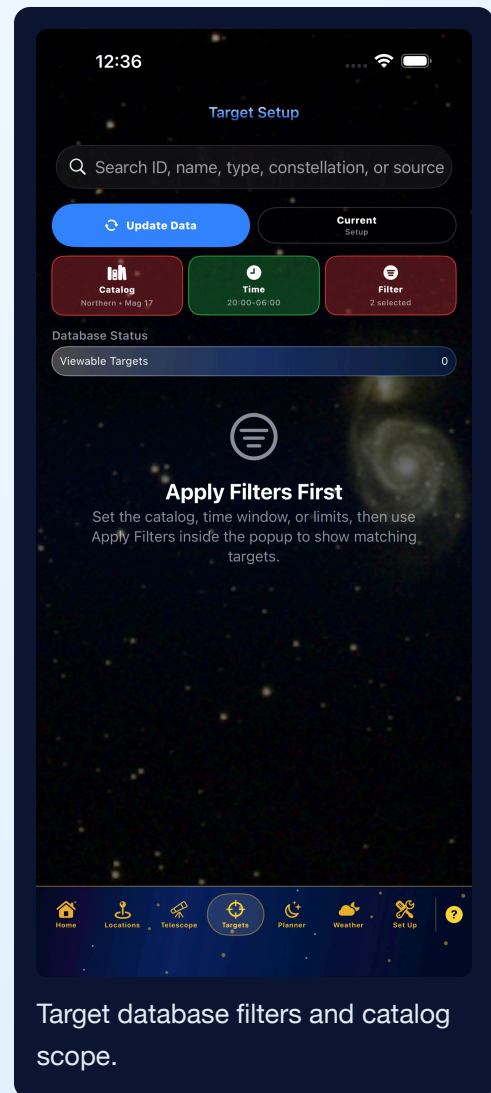
Telescope

- Select the smart telescope used for the observation plan.
- Select compatible accessories before saving the telescope setup.
- Hestia is removed from smart telescope setup because it is a phone accessory, not a true smart telescope.
- The planner report includes selected telescope and accessory names.
- When a telescope is saved as default, the add prompt can return directly to Home Initialization Time.



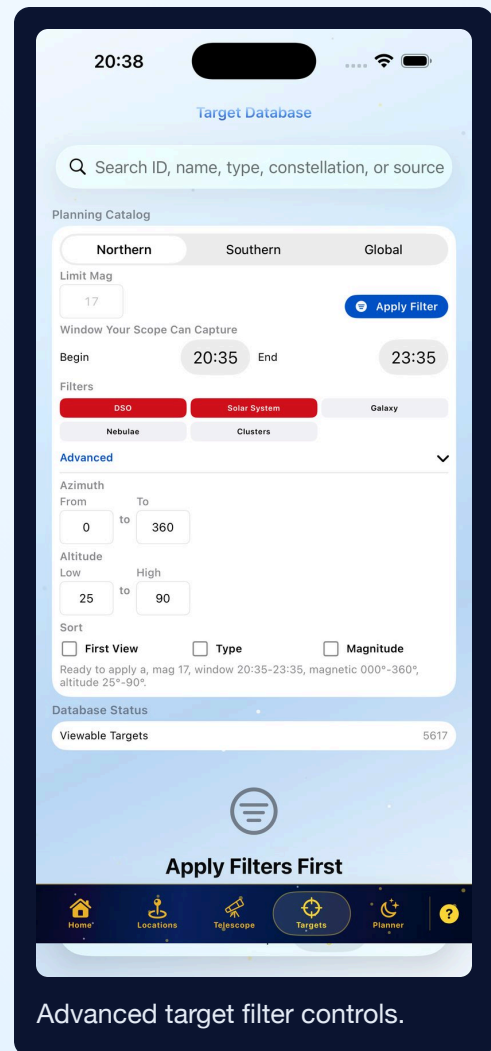
Targets

- Use Update Data when target sources need refreshing.
- Use the Current Setup card to expand or collapse the active target settings summary.
- Catalog, Time, and Filter cards open popups. Apply catalog, time, and filter changes from inside those popups before reviewing the target list.
- Action cards use glass status colors: green when a required setup block is valid, red until required user data is entered or the user has opened a filter without setting it.
- The top Apply action has been removed so Catalog and Current Setup have more room.
- Current target setup is held temporarily, so returning to Target Setup restores the active catalog, time, and filter choices.
- If transient target data is stale, target cards show Update Data and remain disabled until refreshed.



Advanced Filters and Planning

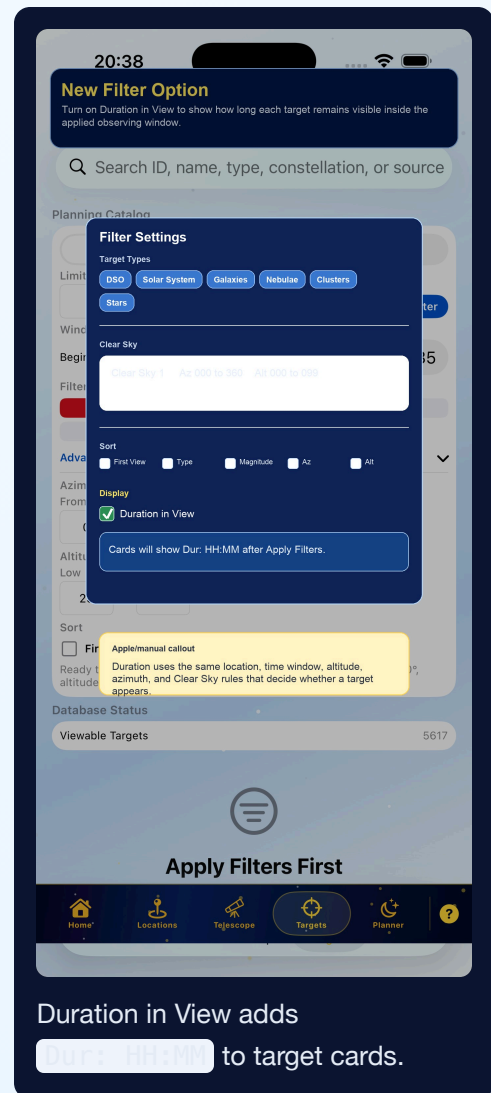
- Use Advanced Filters for magnitude, altitude, magnetic azimuth, object type, and observing-window limits.
- Use Common Databases to select curated object groups such as galaxies, nebulae, clusters, stars, multiple stars, solar system targets, and transients before applying the detailed type filters.
- Altitude limits accept 0 through 99 degrees. Azimuth limits accept 000 through 360 degrees.
- Obstruction ranges remove blocked azimuth or altitude areas from target candidates.
- Clear Sky filter ranges can be added one after another without closing the card, and a new range can be canceled before saving.
- Apply Filter validates required fields. If data is invalid, the app asks for the missing or corrected answer.
- Duration in View is in the Filter popup Display section. After Apply Filters, target cards show Dur: HH:MM beside the first usable window.
- Star targets are included in the bundled local catalog, including bright stars and binary or multiple-star matches when available.
- Details expands a target card to show Min, Opt, and Best capture-duration guidance for the saved default telescope while leaving Check, Sample, and Add Plan available.
- Use Add to Planner for unscheduled targets or Go to Planner for targets already in the plan.

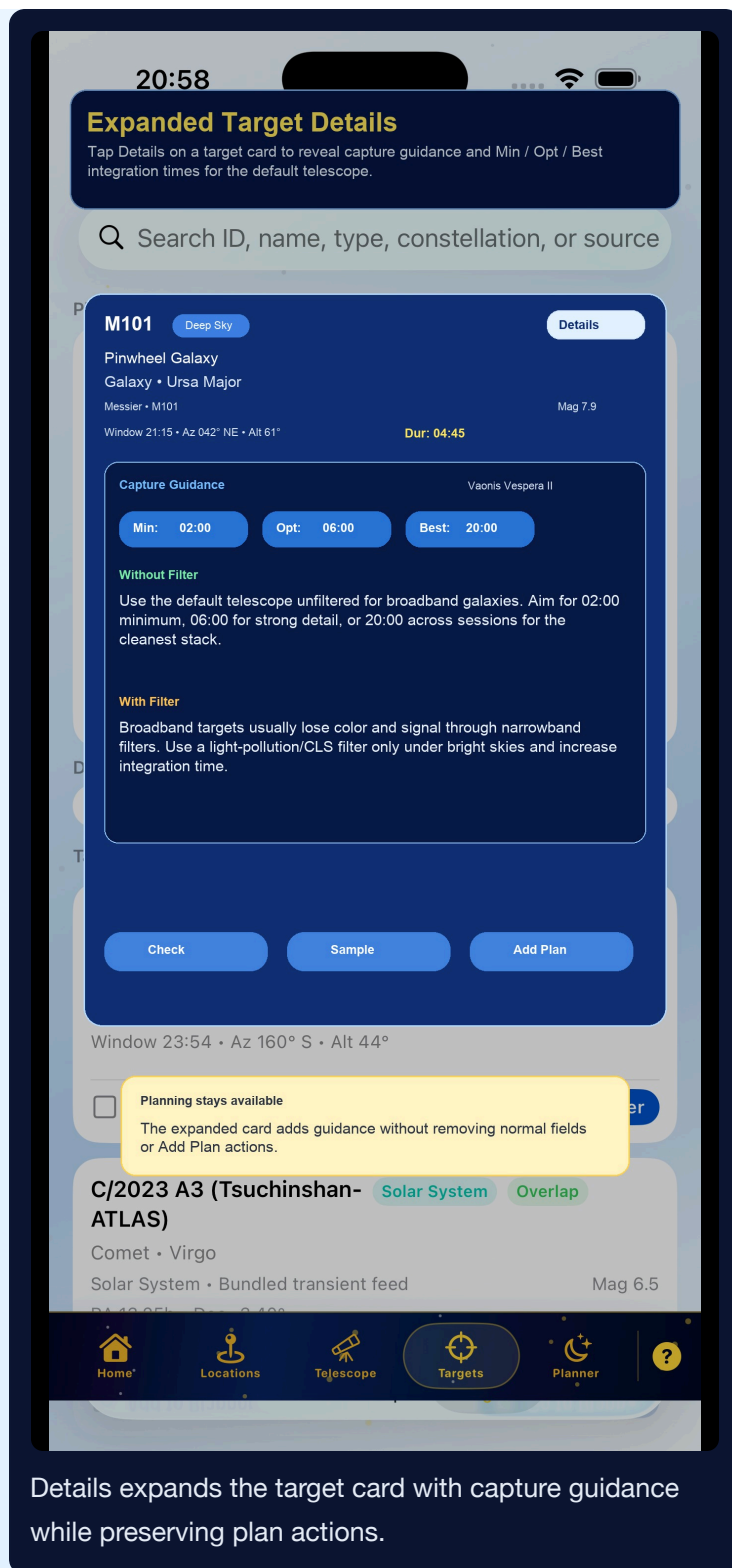


Advanced target filter controls.

Duration and Target Details

- Turn on Duration in View when you want each card to show how long the target stays inside the applied observing window.
- Tap Details on a target card to double the card height and reveal capture guidance for the default telescope.
- The Details panel includes unfiltered and filtered capture notes so broadband galaxies, nebulae, clusters, and Solar System targets can be interpreted differently.

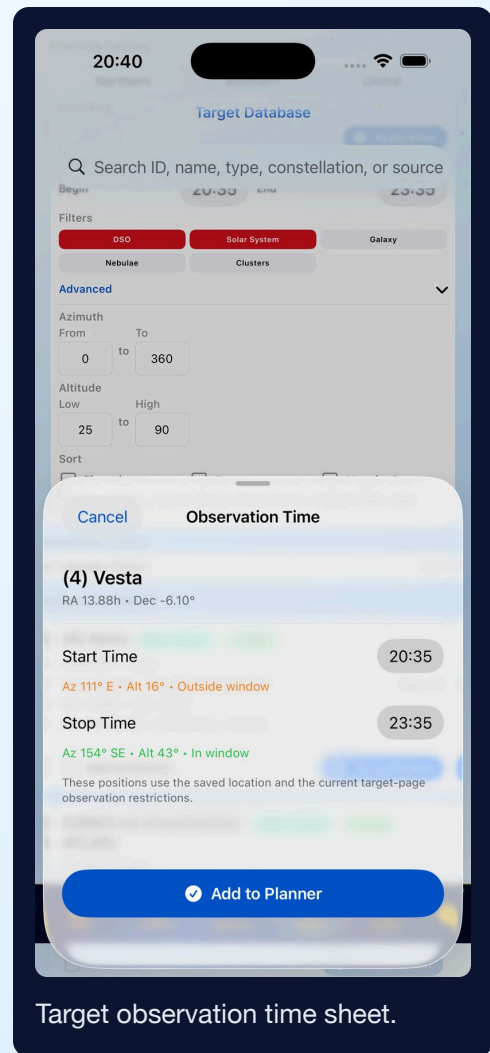




Details expands the target card with capture guidance while preserving plan actions.

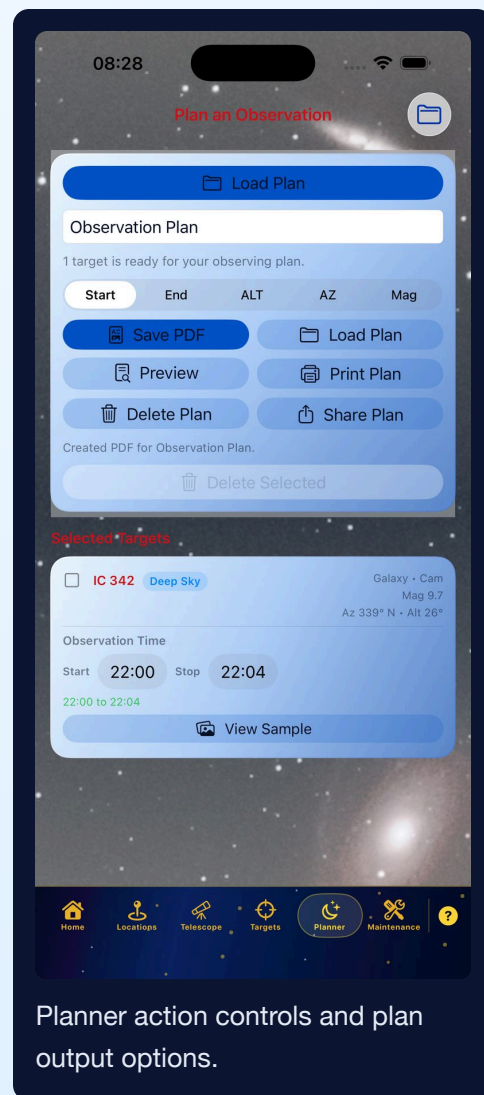
Observation Time

- Set start and stop time for each target.
- After-midnight times are normalized into the same observing night.
- The app checks for overlapping planned target windows before saving.
- When you set a target's end time, that end time becomes the next target's start time in the current planner order.



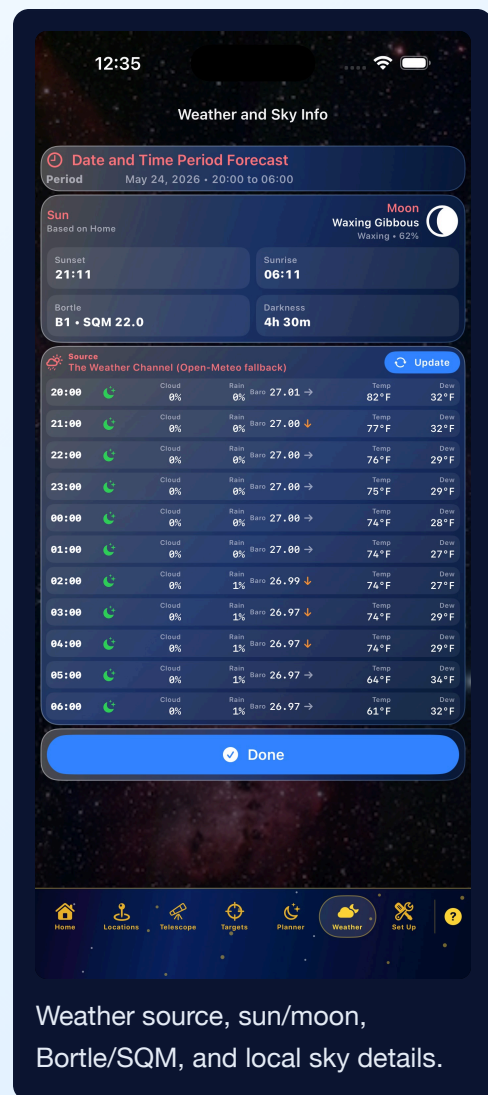
Planner

- Review targets and adjust observation times.
- The plan is shown in start-time order.
- Save PDF, Preview, Print Plan, Delete Plan, Fill Gaps, Load Plan, Share Plan, and Quick Ref are available when a plan is present.
- Fill Gaps suggests matching targets for open windows between scheduled planner targets, using the active filters and saved observing location.
- Fill Gaps includes Sample so you can preview a suggested target before adding it.
- Quick Ref opens a preview of the short field report with target name, first view time, azimuth, and altitude, then exports either PDF or text.
- After Load Plan, choose Yes to add more targets or No to stay on Planner.
- The loaded plan name and loaded-plan message turn yellow.



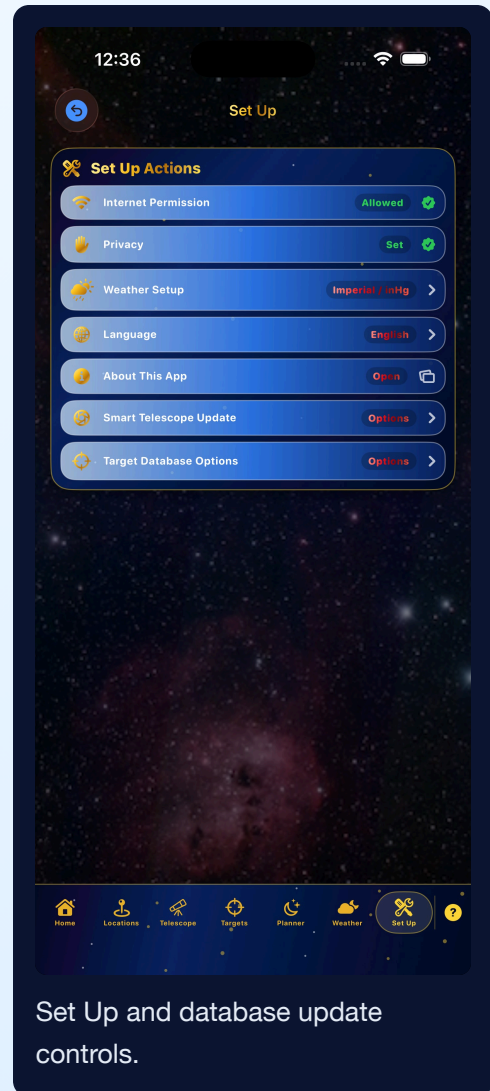
Weather and Sky Info

- Weather uses the default location and observing window.
- If My Telescope times are set, the viewing period follows that initialize/stop window until a saved plan takes over.
- The glass Date and Time Period Forecast card lists the active observing date and time range.
- The Sun/Moon glass card shows Sunset, Sunrise, Vespera Init, Bortle/SQM, and time of total darkness based on the saved location.
- Vespera Init uses the same calibrated Vaonis timing policy that Home applies to Vaonis smart telescopes.
- Bortle/SQM is estimated from the saved latitude, longitude, elevation, and nearby population light-pressure reference used by the app.
- The compact Source row names the weather source and includes Update to reload the hourly data.
- Hourly rows list time, icon, cloud percentage, rain chance, pressure trend, temperature, and dew point.
- The Done action is kept above the menu bar on iPhone.



Set Up

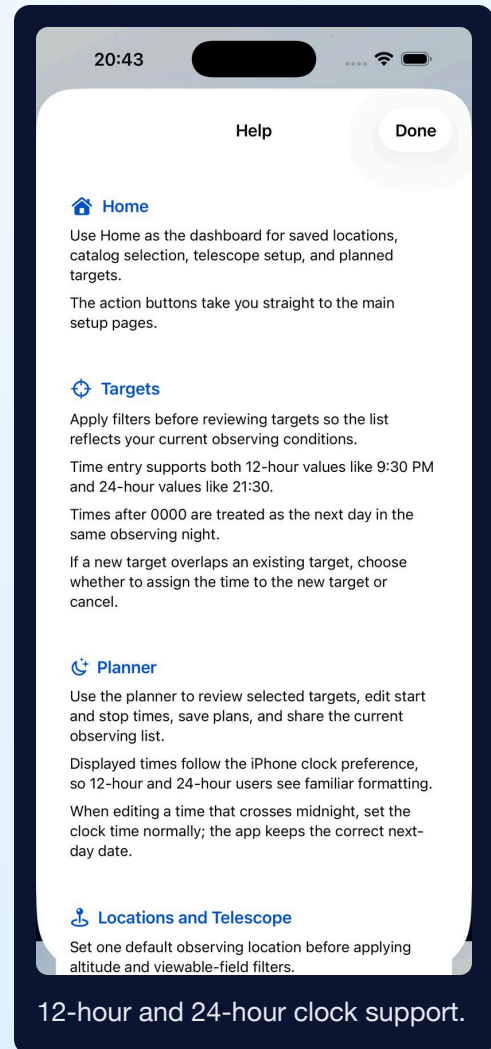
- Set Up contains language, units, internet permission, update actions, and About This App.
- Internet-required actions are labeled.
- Target and smart telescope database updates are user-started.
- Target Database Update summarizes changed transients, lists their names, and shows pulled-and-stored asteroid and comet names such as Ceres and Vesta.
- Off-site pages open inside a controlled in-app browser with a return button.



Set Up and database update controls.

Help and Clock Support

- Open Help from the question mark icon.
- Help mirrors the major manual sections in shorter form.
- Time entry accepts HHMM, 12-hour, and 24-hour formats, while displayed times follow the iPhone or iPad clock preference.



Troubleshooting

No targets appear

- Save a default location.
- Set required red Catalog, Time, or Filter cards, then use Apply Filters inside the popup.
- Loosen magnitude, altitude, azimuth, object type, and obstruction settings.

Weather is blank

- Save a valid default location with latitude and longitude.
- Confirm internet permission for weather prediction data.
- Add elevation when available.

Location will not save

- Enter a location name.
- Use GPS or enter latitude and longitude.
- Choose Country first for manual address entry.

Plan load is blank

- Watch for the Plan Loaded prompt.
- Choose Yes to add targets or No to remain on Planner.
- Yellow plan text identifies a loaded plan.

Numeric text

- Dismiss the keypad after entering the value.
- Scroll cards under the filter card.
- Collapse advanced filters after applying.

Asteroid

- Run Target Database Update from Set Up.
- Review the update summary for Small bodies updated, Pulled and stored, and Changed transients.
- Stale transient target cards cannot be used until data is refreshed.

PDF of Plan

- Confirm at least one target exists in the plan.
- Use Preview first.
- Use Share Plan if the device print sheet is unavailable.

All app data stays on the device. Internet access is used only for selected updates, weather, image lookup, privacy/support pages, and other user-started online actions.

Quick Answer Index

Use this final page when you know the problem or setting but do not remember which topic explains it.

Address Info after GPS

See **Locations**: GPS fills the site, collapses Address Info, and allows it to reopen.

Clear Sky filter ranges

See **Advanced Filters and Results**: add ranges one after another, or cancel a new range.

Add targets to a plan

See **Target Setup**, **Advanced Filters and Results**, and **Observation Time**.

Current Setup summary

See **Target Setup**: expand it to review active catalog, time, and filter settings.

Altitude or azimuth limits

See **Advanced Filters and Results**: altitude is 0 to 99 degrees, azimuth is 000 to 360 degrees.

Default observing location

See **Locations**: only one saved location is active at a time.

Asteroids or comets look stale

See **Set Up** and **Troubleshooting**: run Target Database Update and check the summary.

Filter card is red

See **Target Setup**: open the Filter popup, enter the required data, and apply it.

Bortle, SQM, and darkness

See **Weather and Sky Info**: values are based on the saved location and observing window.

Home telescope time

See **Home**: enter initialize and stop tracking time in HHMM, 12-hour, or 24-hour form.

Catalog card is red

See **Target Setup**: set catalog scope and magnitude, then apply inside the popup.

Hourly weather rows

See **Weather and Sky Info**: rows show time, icon, cloud, rain, pressure, temperature, and dew point.

Internet permission

See **First Start Setup** and **Set Up**: online work is user-started.

Load a saved plan

See **Planner**: choose Yes to add more targets or No to stay on Planner.

No targets appear

See **Troubleshooting**: confirm location, set red cards, and loosen filters.

PDF or print plan

See **Planner** and **Troubleshooting**: preview first, then print, save, or share.

Plan folder

See **First Start Setup**: choose or create a Files folder for saved plan output.

Source of weather

See **Weather and Sky Info**: the source row names the provider and includes Update.

Stale transient target card

See **Target Setup**: disabled cards require Update Data before use.

Sunset and Sunrise

See **Weather and Sky Info**: the Sun/Moon card shows Sunset first and Sunrise second.

Time after midnight

See **Observation Time**: after-midnight values are normalized into the same observing night.

Update Data

See **Target Setup** and **Set Up**: refresh local target and transient data when needed.

Weather is blank

See **Troubleshooting**: save location, confirm internet permission, and include elevation when available.